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Contested *Huaqiao* Identity in Late Colonial Indonesia

A Case Study of Chinese Advertisements in the Thien Sung Yit Po *Anniversary Publications*

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Abstract

Southeast Asia is an important region to examine and problematize Chineseness. Extant research on Chinese-language advertisements in the early twentieth century mainly focuses on China and Singapore, leaving Indonesian cases underexplored. This study examines how Chinese-language advertisements in late colonial Indonesia constructed Chineseness and imagined their audience. This article utilizes advertisements from anniversary editions of the Kuomintang-affiliated *Thien Sung Yit Po* (TSYP, 天聲日報) in the Dutch East Indies around 1930. This study argues that the Chineseness constructed in TSYP's advertisements in late colonial Indonesia was contingent, based on local and transnational sociopolitical and economic context in the late Dutch colony, with hybridity and Chinese modernity intertwined with strategic Chinese nationalism. The findings challenge the essentialized Huaqiao identity disseminated by the Chinese nation-state, highlighting local Chinese agency in late colonial Indonesia.

Keywords

Huaqiao – Chinese Indonesians – advertisements – Chineseness

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1 Introduction[1]

Newspaper advertisements articulated different forms of Chineseness in late colonial Indonesia, reflecting distinct readerships, economic interests, and survival strategies. Previous studies have approached Chinese advertisements in China and Singapore to examine their construction of Chinese identity, but materials of Chinese-language advertisements in late colonial Indonesia remain underexplored. This study utilizes advertisements from two anniversary publications of the Chinese-language newspaper *Thien Sung Yit Po* (TSYP, 天聲日報) affiliated with the Kuomintang (KMT) in late colonial Indonesia, especially in the difficult years surrounding 1930, to examine how the audience was imagined and how Chineseness was constructed. Adopting an archipelagic trope, this study will also consider advertisements in Sino-Malay and Dutch newspapers in the Indies, and Chinese newspapers in the Straits Settlements during the same period for comparison to highlight the characteristics of TSYP's advertisements.

Even though the Republic of China (ROC) attempted to mobilize overseas Chinese through the term *Huaqiao* (華僑), the complex local and transnational social-political and economic contexts of the late colonial Dutch East Indies led to misalignment between TSYP's and the ROC's *Huaqiao* narratives. The main contribution of this paper is to treat *Huaqiao* identity articulated in TSYP's advertisements as contingent, based on local and transnational sociopolitical and economic context, and to challenge the essentialized *Huaqiao* identity.

This paper will first have a brief introduction to heterogeneous Chinese Indonesian communities in the unstable late Dutch colony, and then will do literature review on Chineseness in Southeast Asia, and on Chinese newspapers and advertisements in the region in early twentieth-century. Then the paper will introduce materials and methodology. The discussion will be organized by key features of the advertisements, that is, hybrid Chineseness, competing modernity, and strategic Chinese nationalism. The last part will be the conclusion and prospects for research on Chinese Indonesians.

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2 Indies Chinese and Their Newspapers in Late Colonial Indonesia

Chinese communities exhibited considerable heterogeneity and fluidity in late colonial Indonesia, even though they were categorized as static "foreign Orientals" (*Vreemde Oosterlingen*) by the colonial hierarchical legal system and also as essentialized *Huaqiao* by the ROC. Scholars tend to divide Chinese Indonesians in the late colonial era into Peranakans and Totoks based on the degree of assimilation and places of birth. Local-born, semi-assimilated Peranakans, especially those in Java, were usually Malay-speaking instead of Chinese-speaking due to long-term assimilation and cultural hybridity. New Chinese immigrants (also called Totoks) could speak Chinese languages, and preserved relatively more customs from their Chinese ancestral land. In addition to cultural and linguistic divergence, Peranakans and Totoks also had different identities and economic interests. Complicated sociohistorical contexts and diverse individual experiences could lead Chinese Indonesians to go beyond the Peranakan-Totok dichotomy, showing fluid Chineseness and complex considerations: Peranakans could be resinicized and become more China-oriented, and Totoks could also become more localized.

Peranakans dominated Chinese communities in late colonial Java. Nevertheless, Peranakans and Totoks both encountered an era of transformation in terms of economy and power: Peranakan Chinese merchants lost many of their previous monopolistic economic privileges due to the "Ethical Policy" (*ethische politiek*); Totok merchants played a dominate role for the great expansion of Chinese commercial network in the Indies in the early twentieth century.[2]

Schools in late colonial Indonesia not only reflected divergent socioeconomic and political considerations of the time but contributed to the formation of different identities. Although *Tiong Hoa Hwee Koan* (THHK, 中華會館) schools promoted the resinicization of Peranakans, not all Chinese students attended THHK schools.[3] Many Indies Chinese attended Dutch or Malay schools at that time. Thus heterogeneous and fragmented Chinese were readers of newspapers in different languages in late colonial Indonesia.

2 Monique Erkelens, "Creating the Modern Colonial State: The Intensification of Colonial Rule and Its Effect on the Chinese and the Institution of Chinese officers," in *The Decline of the Chinese Council of Batavia*. (Leiden: Leiden University, 2013), 124–176; Jamie Mackie, "Towkays and Tycoons: The Chinese in Indonesian Economic Life in the 1920s and 1980s," *Indonesia* (1991): 83–96. https://doi.org/10.2307/3351256.

3 Liu Huanran 劉煥然, *Heshu dongyindu gailan* 荷屬東印度概覽 [An overview of the Dutch East Indies] (Singapore: Qianghua Tushu Chubanshe, 1939), 26–37.

Even though both the ROC and the Dutch colonial authorities struggled for control over Indies Chinese, Chinese in the Indies had their own agency in the late Dutch colony. The ROC considered all ethnic Chinese worldwide to be *Huaqiao* and Chinese nationals, and sought to mobilize *Huaqiao* for China's political and economic interests. However, *Huaqiao* is a contested category, which has various interpretations beyond the patriotic and China-oriented narrative.[4] The Dutch colonial authorities regarded all local-born Chinese as their subjects and took actions to curb "Chinese expansionism" from China.[5] In addition, the "Ethical Policy" produced a more interventionist colonial rule in the Dutch East Indies compared to British Malaya. Dutch economic intervention reached its peak during the Great Depression of the 1930s.[6] The Dutch plantation economy expanded rapidly from the 1900s to the 1930s, while excluding Chinese and indigenous producers from the sector.[7] A large number of Chinese merchants shifted their business activities to retail trade and small-scale industry for survival.[8] Many Indies Chinese accepted Chinese nationalism as a choice under harsh conditions of late colonial society, but many also sought to gain a more favorable status under the Dutch colonial framework.

Fragmented Chinese-owned newspapers in late colonial Indonesia articulated divergent political orientations and identities strategically based on shifting local and transnational sociopolitical and economic circumstances. Malay was the lingua franca in print media in the archipelago. Many Peranakan Chinese elites exchanged their opinions in Chinese-owned Malay publications (Sino-Malay publications) despite their divergent political

4 Kuik Ching-Sue. *Un/Becoming Chinese:* Huaqiao, *the Non-Perishable Sojourner Reinvented, and Alterity of Chineseness* (PhD diss. University of Washington, 2013), 165–168.

5 Donald E. Willmott, *The National Status of the Chinese in Indonesia 1900–1958* (Cornell University, 1961), 1–12;

Liu Oiyan, "Countering 'Chinese Imperialism': Sinophobia and Border Protection in the Dutch East Indies," Indonesia 97 (2014): 87–110. https://doi.org/10.5728/indonesia.97.0087.

6 Nicholas J. White, "The Settlement of Decolonization and Post-Colonial Economic Development. Indonesia, Malaysia, and Singapore Compared," *Bijdragen tot de taal-, land- en volkenkunde/Journal of the Humanities and Social Sciences of Southeast Asia*, 173(2–3) (2017): 208–241; See also Howard Dick, Houben Vincent JH, Lindblad J. Thomas, and Thee Kian Wie, *Emergence of a National Economy: An Economic History of Indonesia, 1800–2000* (University of Hawaii Press, 2002), 111–152.

7 Mackie, "Towkays and Tycoons," 83–96.

8 Mackie, "Towkays and Tycoons," 83–96.

orientations.[9] The political stances of Peranakan Chinese in Java before WWII can be simply divided into pro-China, pro-Dutch, and pro-Indonesia groups.[10] Although the language of Sino-Malay newspapers inevitably showed Chinese characteristics, Sino-Malay newspapers had a cross-ethnic readership.[11] Chinese-language newspapers in late colonial Indonesia were relatively more China-oriented, but also showed local Chinese agency. Even though Chinese-language newspapers did not have as much of an inter-ethnic readership as Sino-Malay newspapers, Chinese-language newspapers still served as an important site connecting Totoks and China-oriented Peranakans. One of the mainstream Chinese-language newspapers, TSYP, was the mouthpiece of the KMT and the ROC in the Dutch East Indies.[12] The more influential *Sin Po* also had its Chinese version, though its issues published in the late colonial era are mostly not accessible now.

The declining Dutch colonial authorities enforced stringent political repression and newspaper censorship during the late period of their rule. Various local and transnational political movements and organizations in the 1920s, such as growing Chinese nationalism and Indonesian nationalism, and the *Partai Komunis Indonesia* (PKI, Communist Party of Indonesia) triggered anxiety in the Dutch colonial authorities. After the suppression of the PKI revolts in 1927, newspaper censorship and political repression were more stringent in the Dutch East Indies. The Dutch colonial authorities imposed extremely strict censorship on communist and anti-colonial content, and there were no mainstream pro-communist Chinese newspapers in the archipelago.[13] The unusually harsh censorship regime further underscored the Dutch Empire's geopolitical vulnerability.[14]

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9 Tom G Hoogervorst, "Chineseness in Sino-Malay printing: a triptych of self-criticism," *Inter-Asia Cultural Studies* 24, no. 4 (2023): 678–693. https://doi.org/10.1080/14649373.2023.2221496.

10 Leo Suryadinata, *Peranakan Chinese Politics in Java 1917–1942* (Singapore: Singapore University Press, 1976), 85–105.

11 Tom G Hoogervorst, "What Kind of Language was 'Chinese Malay' in Late Colonial Java?" *Indonesia and the Malay World* 45, no. 133 (2017): 294–314. https://doi.org/10.1080/13639811.2017.1340030; There were over thirty Sino-Malay newspapers in 1935 in the Indies, see Centraal Kantoor voor de Statistiek, "70: Overzicht van der pers," in *Indisch Verslag 1936: Statistisch jaaroverzicht van Nederlandsch-Indië over het jaar 1935*. (Batavia: Landsdrukkerij, 1937), 102.

12 As repeatedly praised in congratulatory messages from Chinese overseas associations, the newspaper was lauded as "the mouthpiece of the Party-State" (*Dangguo houshe* 黨國喉舌).

13 David Borgonjon, *Red Nanyang: Chinese-Language Literature of Indonesia, 1945–1965* (PhD diss., Columbia University, 2025), 51–60.

14 Yamamoto Nobuto, *Censorship in Colonial Indonesia, 1901–1942* (Brill, 2019), 257.

The *persdelict* (press offence) introduced in 1914 shaped an era of commercial and consumption-driven newspaper content.[15] Advertisements in multilingual newspapers were not totally independent, but intertwined with each other due to connected commercial networks and dynamic sociopolitical environments. Thus late colonial Indonesian Chinese newspaper advertisements serve as an important site of the construction of Chineseness.

3 Literature Review

Southeast Asia is an important region to examine and problematize Chineseness. The term "*Huaqiao*" is controversial in Southeast Asia, with its historical roots transcending contemporary geopolitical and ideological confrontation. Ong emphasizes the marginal position of the *Huaqiao* within Chinese nationalist discourse.[16] Kuik argues that despite being used to disseminate a monolithic and essentialized Chinese identity, *Huaqiao* is also a contested category like Chineseness.[17] In addition, Xie argues that Chinese diasporic participation in China's National Salvation Movement was not driven solely by Chinese nationalism, but was also shaped by changing local political, economic, and social circumstances.[18] This study will situate multilingual advertisements within local and translocal sociopolitical and historical contexts to examine the contingent construction of *Huaqiao* identity in late colonial Indonesia (more precisely, around 1930).

Despite extensive research on Chinese newspaper advertisements in China and Singapore to examine Chineseness, very few studies have examined Chinese-language advertisements in Indonesia. Extant scholarships on Chinese advertisements in China and Singapore in early twentieth century have focused on Chinese community image, imagined community of readers, consumer culture, modernity, and nationalism.[19] In addition, studies on inter-

15 Ibid, 19.

16 Ong Soon Keong. "'Chinese, But Not Quite': *Huaqiao* and the Marginalization of the Overseas Chinese," *Journal of Chinese Overseas* 9, no. 1 (2013): 1–32. https://doi.org/10.1163/17932548-12341247.

17 Kuik, "Un/Becoming Chinese," 165–168.

18 Xie Kankan, "Ambivalent Fatherland: The Chinese National Salvation Movement in Malaya and Java, 1937–41," *Journal of Southeast Asian Studies* 52, no. 4 (2021): 677–700. https://doi.org/10.1017/S0022463421000989.

19 Wu Yongmei 吳詠梅, and Lee Pui Tak 李培德, *Tuxiang yu shangye wenhua: Fenxi zhongguo jindai guanggao* 圖像與商業文化: 分析中國近代廣告 [Graphic images and consumer culture: Analysis of modern advertising culture in China] (Hong Kong: Hong Kong

lingual comparisons of Chinese advertisements have also focused on hybridity, transformation, and discrepancy between different discourses.[20] Hoogervorst has thoroughly examined Peranakan-controlled Sino-Malay newspapers in late colonial Indonesia, focusing on commercialization, entertainment, and modernity as well as cultural and linguistic hybridity; yet there remains a lack of research on Chinese-language materials concerning less assimilated Chineseness.[21] In addition, Hoogervorst's examination of Sino-Malay newspapers pays much attention to the vernacular culture, while the high politicized Chinese-language TSYP requires more sociopolitical contextualization.

This study will fill the gap through approaching advertisements in the Chinese-language newspaper TSYP in late colonial Indonesia in order to examine the contingently constructed Chineseness. This study will utilize advertisements in TSYP and other multilingual newspapers to examine how audiences were imagined and how Chineseness was constructed in the turbulent late-colonial era Indonesia.

4 Methodology

Stuart Hall argued that cultural identity is "not an essence but a positioning."[22] This paper approaches Chinese advertisements in late colonial newspapers in Indonesia as sites where identity is contingently and strategically constructed. Instead of reflecting a fixed *Huaqiao* identity, these advertisements position

University Press. 2014); Yeo Mang Thong, *Migration, Transmission, Localisation: Visual Art in Singapore (1886–1945)* (Singapore: National Gallery Singapore, 2019).

20 Liu Chunyao, Lian Liu, and Erin Cunningham, "Towards a Cross-Cultural Hybridisation: An Exploration of Furniture Design and Advertising in Shanghai, China (1912–1949)," *Fabrications* 33, no. 2 (2023): 306–331. https://doi.org/10.1080/10331867.2024.2320985; Li Bo, "Transadvertising of Western Pharmaceutical Products in The Chinese Mail (1895–1910)," *Perspectives* 30, no. 2 (2022): 343–359. https://doi.org/10.1080/0907676X.2021.1887300.

21 Tom G Hoogervorst, *Language Ungoverned: Indonesia's Chinese Print Entrepreneurs, 1911–1949* (Cornell University Press, 2021); Tom Hoogervorst, and Nordholt Henk Schulte. "Urban Middle Classes in Colonial Java (1900–1942): Images and Language," *Bijdragen tot de taal-, land-en volkenkunde/Journal of the Humanities and Social Sciences of Southeast Asia* 173, no. 4 (2017): 442–474. https://doi.org/10.1163/22134379-17304002.

22 Stuart Hall, "Cultural Identity and Diaspora," in *Colonial Discourse and Post-Colonial Theory*. (Routledge, 2015), 392–403.

the merchants and their products differently depending on the imagined audience of the publications.[23]

The major material in this study is *Thien Sung Yit Po* (TSYP). Established in 1921, TSYP was a KMT-affiliated Chinese-language newspaper based in Batavia that maintained close ties with branches of the KMT in the Indies. It was also one of the mainstream Chinese-language newspapers in late colonial Java.[24] Its readership was mainly Totoks and China-oriented Peranakans. Most of the staff and board members originated from Meixian (梅縣, or Moiyan in Hakka), China, and were Hakka.[25] Unfortunately, most of the Chinese-language newspapers in late colonial Indonesia are mostly unavailable now.[26]

The main materials this paper utilizes are advertisements in the seventh (1928) and tenth (1931) anniversary publications of the Chinese-language newspaper TSYP. The main readers of TSYP were Totoks and Chinese-educated Peranakans. Some mainstream and accessible newspapers in Java and Singapore at the same era, such as China-oriented Sino-Malay newspaper *Sin Po*, and Singapore-based mainstream Chinese-language newspapers, will be strategically utilized for comparison to emphasize the unique feature of TSYP's advertisements.[27] Other related Sino-Malay and Dutch newspapers will sometimes be considered to highlight characteristics of TSYP's advertisements.

This study treats advertisements as sites of everyday identity construction for their imagined audience. The main materials are limited to two available anniversary publications of TSYP. Since Chinese-language materials are often difficult to access in research on Chinese Indonesians, this limitation is not unusual. These advertisements still serve as important and underexplored materials to examine Chineseness. As TSYP was based in Batavia, its

23 Alice E. Marwick, and Boyd Danah, "I Tweet Honestly, I Tweet Passionately: Twitter Users, Context Collapse, and the Imagined Audience," *New Media & Society* 13, no. 1 (2011): 114–133. https://doi.org/10.1177/1461444810365313.

24 Its circulation before 1937 was 3,000. It also got subsidy from the Consulate General of China. See Yamamoto, "Censorship in Colonial Indonesia," 269.

25 The tenth anniversary edition contained a listing of TSYP's staff and board members. Most of the editors were Hakka Totoks born in Meixian. Their places of birth can also be obtained from Chinese-language sources that document famous patriotic overseas Chinese, such as Guangdong Sheng Difang Shizhi Bianzuan Weiyuanhui 廣東省地方史志編纂委員會, *Guangdong shengzhi: Huaqiao zhi* 廣東省志: 華僑志 [Gazetteer of Guangdong Province: Overseas Chinese volume] (Guangzhou: Guangdong Remin Chubanshe, 1996).

26 Leo Suryadinata, *The Orientation of Chinese Newspapers in Indonesia as China Rises* (ISEAS-Yusof Ishak Institute, 2023); Borgonjon, "Red Nanyang," 589.

27 The Chinese newspapers in Singapore adopted included *Nanyang Siang Pau* (南洋商報) and *Sin Chew Jit Poh* (星洲日報) .

advertisements inevitably show Java-centrism and even Batavia-centrism. Should other Chinese-language newspapers in late colonial Indonesia become available, they could provide a basis for comparison with this research.

5 Bounded Hybrid Chineseness

Peranakan Chinese dominated Javanese Chinese communities in the early twentieth century. Peranakans and Totoks exhibited different forms of Chineseness, with the former being more hybrid due to long-term assimilation and the latter relatively more essentialized. In addition, the two groups of Chinese also had fragmented political orientations and economic interests. Despite TSYP's editors' Meixian Hakka Totok background, TSYP's considerations for a broader Peranakan readership caused its advertisements to balance different forms of Chineseness in the Dutch East Indies. Thus TSYP's advertisements display bounded hybrid Chineseness. This section will also briefly compare the hybridity of TSYP advertisements with those in Sino-Malay *Sin Po* and Chinese newspapers in Singapore of the same period.

Most Peranakan Chinese in Java had lost their Chinese language ability by the early twentieth century due long-term assimilation, while a substantial proportion of the Chinese population in late colonial Singapore were still China-born Chinese.[28] Compared with mainstream Chinese newspapers in Singapore from the same period, TSYP's advertisements exhibit more hybridity.[29] TSYP's advertisements included more introductions in Malay and Western languages, with Chinese introductions being much shorter than those in Singapore's Chinese newspapers.

Advertisements for both Western-style and traditional Chinese products in TSYP showcase hybridity due to the archipelagic context. These advertisements reflected expectations that Chinese elites in the archipelago would combine Chinese, Western, and indigenous cultures.

One of the most common types of newspaper advertisements featured Western-style products manufactured or distributed by Chinese merchants, showcasing Sino-Western hybrid Chineseness. Figure 1 shows the advertisement for carbonated and mineral waters produced by a local Chinese company, Lourdes.[30] Although the advertisement was presented in the Chinese

28 Hoogervorst, "Language Ungoverned," 2850.

29 *Nanyang Siang Pau* and *Sin Chew Jit Poh* are considered here.

30 The Dutch name of the company was *N.V. Handel Mij. Mineraalwater Fabriek Lourdes*, and its Chinese name was *Lutuo Qishui Gongsi* (盧托汽水公司). The company was established by *Chen Longji* (陳隆吉).



FIGURE 1 Advertisement of Lourdes products.
SOURCE: SEVENTH ANNIVERSARY EDITION OF *THIEN SUNG YIT PO,* 1928.

language, the product packaging prominently features the Dutch language, reflecting the product's characteristics of Western modernity. The labelling of the main product with the term "sarsaparilla" makes reference to the herb used in Traditional Chinese Medicine (TCM).[31] Together, these served as an effective marketing strategy to promote foreign-introduced products to Chinese-educated customers. The advertisement constructed transcultural Chineseness, blending traditional Chinese cultural elements with Western modernity. The advertisers sought to traverse boundaries between Chinese and Western medical discourses to introduce Western products in TCM terms.[32] This implies an expectation that Chinese elites in the Dutch East Indies should maintain their Chinese roots despite leading Westernized urban lifestyles.

Beyond advertisements for Western-style products, another common type that shows hybrid Chineseness is advertisements for TCM products. These advertisements did not necessarily promote essentialized Chineseness, even though they marketed typical Chinese products. On the contrary, they often incorporated local terms alongside expressions of Chinese ethno-nationalism. Figure 2 shows an advertisement which promoted locally-produced TCM

31 The Chinese name of sarsaparilla is 沙示水 (*shashishui*).

32 Sarah Mellors Rodriguez, "Buying into Reproductive Modernity: Tracing the Transnational History of Two Contraceptives in Britain and China," *Social History of Medicine* 36, no. 3 (2023): 472–498. https://doi.org/10.1093/shm/hkad007.



FIGURE 2 Advertisement to promote locally produced TCM products with China-imported raw ingredients.
SOURCE: SEVENTH ANNIVERSARY EDITION OF *THIEN SUNG YIT PO,* 1928.

products with China-imported raw ingredients. This advertisement emphasized the "authentic" Chineseness of its *zuguo* (祖國, motherland) origin, and aimed to evoke diasporic Chinese nationalism in the audience. The Malay slogans and Malay names of Chinese medicines showed local advertisement styles. Half of the Malay names of the TCM medicines used Hokkien (the dominant local Chinese dialect) loanwords, and the rest used Malay terms, showing the mixture of Hokkien Chinese and Batavian Malay cultures. Even for Traditional Chinese Medicine "entirely produced in China" (*wanquan guochan*, 完全國產), advertisements still adapted the products to the local context.[33] The advertisement implies exposure of the imagined audience to both Chinese and Batavian Malay cultures, alongside support for diasporic Chinese nationalism. This indicates that *Huaqiao* identity is not always tied to

33 See a full-page insert advertisement placed between pages C and D of the tenth anniversary edition of *Thien Sung Yit Po,* 1931.

essentialized Chinese cultural elements but can also be shaped by local transcultural contexts.

Male Peranakan merchants were expected to master basic traditional Chinese literacy for purposes of running a business in the late eighteen century. In the early twentieth century, most modern Chinese-medium schools in the Dutch East Indies had local-born students; thus, the imagined audience could include a large portion of Chinese-educated elites who could also speak Malay and understand local culture to some degree.[34] Advertisements had to consider the cultural and linguistic contexts of local-born Chinese for a broader market beyond Malay-speaking multilingual Chinese.

Even though advertisements in the TSYP exhibited hybridity due to Peranakan dominance in Java and the multiracial colonial society, the relatively conservative nature of written Mandarin Chinese language and Chinese-character printing disabled TSYP's advertisements' use of unofficial Chinese characters or local creole Mandarin or Chinese dialect variants to show linguistic hybridity as Sin Po's advertisements did. Moreover, the norms of written Chinese usually excluded the usage of Latin alphabets, so the introductions in Chinese and other languages in advertisements remained separate.[35] There were also advertisements in TSYP which had Chinese introductions only. In addition, the advertising imagery in TSYP did not feature representations of other local ethnic groups, as was the case in *Sin Po*; rather, it featured predominantly Chinese and Westerners. Thus the hybridity of TSYP's advertisements is a bounded one compared to Sino-Malay newspapers.

Archipelagic Chinese had and have heterogeneous linguistic, cultural, and educational backgrounds.[36] Despite increasing Totok commercial influence in the Dutch East Indies, Peranakans still dominated local Chinese politics in Java.[37] Peranakans' dominance and the multi-ethnic society caused TSYP's advertisements to exhibit hybridity for economic interests. In addition, the

34 According to *Heshu gebu Tongqiao Xuexiao diaochabiao* 荷屬各埠同僑學校調查表 from the tenth anniversary edition of *Thien Sung Yit Po*, 1931. Peranakans were called *Qiaosheng* (僑生 overseas-born Chinese) in the Chinese language at that time.

35 The analysis of TSYP's advertisements draws on Hoogervorst's analysis of Sino-Malay newspapers' linguistic hybridity. See Hoogervorst, "Language Ungoverned," 51–76.

36 Josh Stenberg, Kung Chien-Wen, and Setijadi Charlotte, "From *pulau* to *pulo*: Archipelagic Perspectives on Southeast Asian Chinese ethnicity from the Philippines and Indonesia," *Asian Ethnicity* 24, no. 1 (2023): 1–6. https://doi.org/10.1080/14631369.2022.2132914; Hew Wai Weng, "Archipelagic Chineseness: Competing Ways of being Chinese Muslims in Contemporary Indonesia and Malaysia," *Asian Ethnicity* 24, no. 1 (2023): 132–150. https://doi.org/10.1080/14631369.2022.2122396.

37 Xie, "Ambivalent Fatherland," 677–700.

Dutch colonial authorities prioritized the censorship of the Chinese-language newspaper, instead of regulating and spreading "correct" Chinese language and culture. Thus the styles of TSYP's advertisements occupied a space at the intersection of multiple languages and cultures. This also reflected the localization of the KMT-affiliated TSYP in response to the local readership and local socioeconomic environment. Despite the increasing influence of Totok tycoons and many Totoks' anxiety of the "foreignization" of overseas Chinese, TSYP's advertisements undoubtedly reflected the Peranakanized side of the *Huaqiao* identity. As the intersection of Totoks and Peranakans, TSYP articulated bounded hybrid Chinesness in advertisements. The hybrid Chineseness constructed in TSYP's advertisements combined Chinese, Western, and indigenous elements in response to the archipelagic context, thereby challenging essentialized *Huaqiao* culture and identity.[38] The hybrid Chineseness of TSYP's advertisements also substantiates Ong's argument that the term "*Huaqiao*" implies that the Chinese nation-state regarded overseas Chinese as insufficiently "Chinese."[39]

6 A Competing Modernity

The competing modernity of TSYP's advertisements, in this section, can be reflected in its Nanyang epistemology and surviving strategies to extreme strict censorship. Unfair treatment in the Dutch East Indies caused Indies Chinese to pursue different versions of modernity in order to gain equal sociopolitical status in the early twentieth century.[40] TSYP's modernity was a localized Chinese modernity, instead of a Dutch colonial hegemonic one, or a China-centric one. The epistemology in this section refers to Nanyang epistemology articulated in the Chinese-language, which reflects local lived experience and transnational commercial network.

38 Leo Suryadinata, "Indonesian Chinese Education: Past and Present," *Indonesia* 14 (1972): 49–71. https://doi.org/10.2307/3350732; Liu Jixuan 劉繼宣, Shu Shicheng 束世澂, *Zhonghua minzu tuozhi Nanyang shi* 中華民族拓殖南洋史 [A history of settler colonialism of the Chinese nation in Nanyang] (National Institute for Compilation and Translation, 1934), 232–238; Mackie, "Towkays and Tycoons," 83–96.

39 Ong, "Chinese, But Not Quite," 1–32.

40 Xie Kankan. "Harnessing Nationalism: Competition in Chinese Education in the Late-Colonial Dutch East Indies," in *Empire Competition: Southeast Asia as a Site of Imperial Contestation*, ed. Amy Freedman and Joseph Tse Hei-Lee. (New York: Pace University Press, 2021), 109–131.

Sai has examined THHK's Peranakan agency in articulating their own Chinese modernity in the repressive Dutch colony, rejecting their role as passive subjects of the China-centric influence.[41] On the contrary, the public *Hollandsch-Chineesche School* (Dutch-Chinese School) spread Dutch modernity to counter Chinese modernity from THHK schools. In addition, as the Dutch colonial authorities implemented much stricter newspaper censorship after the suppression of PKI in 1927, competition over modernity was more covert within advertising images, and was part of everyday contestation. The advertisements in TSYP articulated a competing modernity that was temporarily less antagonistic to Eurocentric modernity.

The 1931 anniversary issue of TSYP featured articles and reports addressing the political, economic, and educational conditions in both the Indies and China, reflecting their epistemology of Nanyang and Chinese communities. The advertisements in TSYP actively participated in shaping how Chinese communities in the Indies imagined Nanyang and understood themselves. One type of advertisement was for books, which reflected a Chinese version of epistemology of Nanyang and Chinese modernity.

Figure 3 displays an advertisement promoting a book on situations of Nanyang written by an official from the Ministry of Foreign Affairs of the ROC, Qiu Shouyu (丘守愚). The advertisement claimed that this book was a travelogue of the Chinese official in Nanyang, encompassing not only discussions of economic and cultural conditions of the Dutch East Indies but also insights into scientific and artistic subjects. A currently available book on Nanyang written by Qiu Shouyu is *Ershi Shiji Zhi Nanyang* (二十世紀之南洋), which is used here as an alternative reference since the book in the advertisement could not be located.[42] Qiu felt discontent with Western colonial dominance in Nanyang despite Chinese's long history of settler colonialism in the region. In response to this historical situation, the book aimed to provide Chinese settlers and sojourners in Nanyang with knowledge of the region's political, economic, historical, geographical, cultural, and commercial circumstances. The imagined audience of the advertisement in Figure 3 were Chinese-educated Totoks and Peranakans who aimed at gaining a deeper understanding of the situations of the Dutch East Indies and other territories in Nanyang. Given that TSYP published various articles on the situation of the Chinese nation

41 Sai Siew-Min. "Mandarin Lessons: Modernity, Colonialism and Chinese Cultural Nationalism in the Dutch East Indies, c. 1900s," *Inter-Asia Cultural Studies* 17, no. 3 (2016): 375–394. https://doi.org/10.1080/14649373.2016.1217635.

42 See Qiu Shouyu 丘守愚, *Ershi shiji zhi Nanyang* 二十世紀之南洋 [Nanyang in the twentieth century] (Shanghai: Commercial Press, 1935).

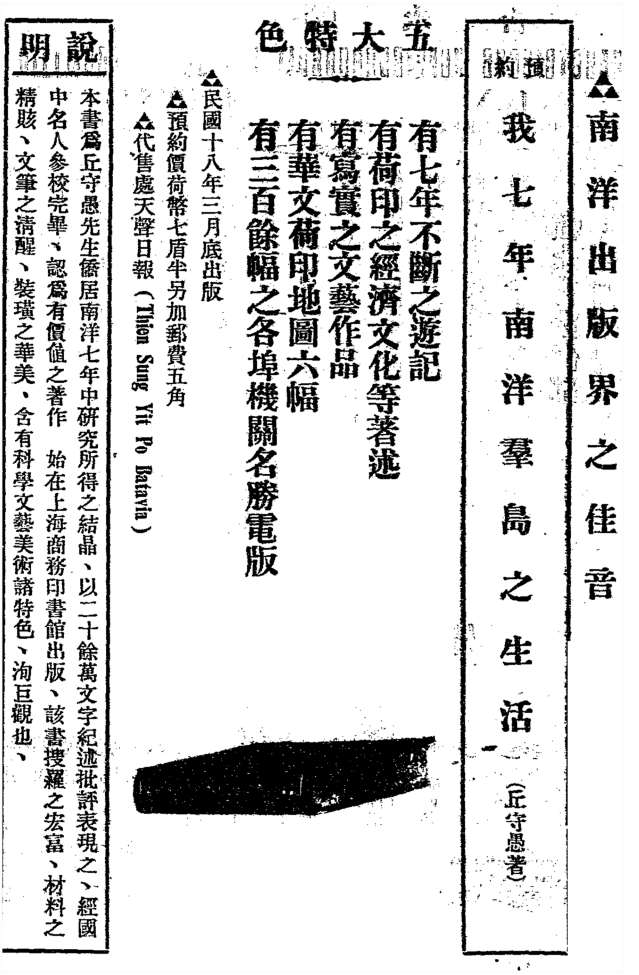


FIGURE 3 Advertisement to promote books on Nanyang.
SOURCE: SEVENTH ANNIVERSARY EDITION OF *THIEN SUNG YIT PO,* 1928.

and the Nanyang region, especially the Indies, its intended audience included merchants seeking to expand their business networks, as well as elites interested in contemporary sociopolitical and economic circumstances in the Indies and China. The advertisement also implied that Chineseness in the Indies was recognized as not being completely the same as that in China, and suggested that Chinese in the Indies should be well-informed about local realities and should compete with Western epistemological hegemony. TSYP's 1931 anniversary issue also included an advertisement promoting Malay-

Dutch-English-Chinese dictionaries to enable readers to expand their influence in an interracial and interregional market. The 1931 anniversary issue also featured Chinese translations of five Malay love songs to attract Peranakan readers and to enable Totok readers to better know local culture.[43]

TSYP's Nanyang epistemology was inevitably influenced by Jinan University (暨南大學) and the ROC.[44] However, TSYP's Nanyang epistemology also reflected an emerging process of localization, as the commercialized TSYP had to take into account the needs of local Indies Chinese subscribers, while some of the writers were scholars who had long resided in the Indies and had taught at THHK schools.[45] TSYP's Nanyang epistemology stands for a third path of knowledge on the region. It was a partially localized epistemology, different from both the China-centric one and the Dutch colonial hegemonic one.

It was important for Totoks to construct the epistemology of the local colonial society and the region, as their urgent objective was adaptation to the local society and the achievement of economic stability. While Peranakans reinvented the epistemology of their identity and culture, as Peranakans they had to deal with an identity crisis in late colonial Indonesia.[46] The China-oriented Sino-Malay newspaper *Sin Po* featured content about Chinese ancestral culture and China. There were ancient Chinese paintings, photos of China at that time, and China news, while TSYP gave greater attention to contemporary affairs, such as the industrial and commercial conditions in the Indies and strategies for advancing the status of the Indies Chinese. Pro-Dutch Sino-Malay newspapers articulated an epistemology more aligned with Dutch modernity.

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43 Liao Nanou 廖南鷗, "*Baroe,"* in the tenth anniversary edition of *Thien Sung Yit Po*, 1931, F27-F35.

44 One of the articles in TSYP's 1931 anniversary issue was written by 國立暨南大學南洋文化事業部 (Nanyang Cultural Affairs Bureau at Jinan University), and many articles were written by scholars who had professional affiliation with Jinan University, such as Li Changfu 李長傅, Chen Anren 陳安仁, and Chen Mingeng 陳民耿. See also Leander Seah 謝枝嶙, "Between East Asia and Southeast Asia: Nanyang Studies, Chinese Migration, and National Jinan University, 1927–1940 (在東亞與東南亞之間: 南洋研究, 華人移民, 與國立暨南大學, 1927–1940)," *Translocal Chinese: East Asian Perspectives* 11, no. 1 (2017): 30–56. https://doi.org/10.1163/24522015-01101004.

45 For example, Liu Shimu 劉士木, Huang Sufeng 黃素封, and Situ Zan 司徒贊.

46 THHK's stated objectives include promoting traditional Chinese culture based on Confucian teachings and providing educational opportunities among Chinese children in the Indies. Nio Joe Lan, "Bij het 40-jarig Jubileum van de Tiong Hoa Hwe Koan-Batavia," *Koloniale Studien*, (1940): 287–311.

Chinese-, Dutch-, and Malay-language newspaper advertisements diverged in their articulation of modernity. Dutch newspapers spread the Eurocentric civilizing mission. Some Malay and Dutch advertisements often reinforced stereotypical Chinese images to emphasize Western modernity and to mark the Chinese as the Other.[47] After the suppression of the revolt of the PKI in 1926–1927, the Dutch colonial authorities strengthened censorship of subversive speech and suppression of subversive political activities.[48] The censorship apparatus focused on anti-Western sentiments in Chinese newspapers.[49] The advertisements in TSYP around 1930 provided an image of competing modernity, but were not confrontational.

The Dutch canned food company *Tieleman & Dros* employed a stereotypical image of a Qing-dynasty-style Chinese man consuming Western food to promote its modern canned products in the Sino-Malay newspaper *Djawa Tengah.*[50] During the same period, the company's Dutch-language advertisements featured only Europeans, as embodiments of modernity by the colonial power.[51] This Sino-Malay advertisement depicted Chinese people as subjects to be modernised by the West, reflecting the wish of a segment of Malay-speaking Peranakans to embrace Western modernity. It also reinforced the stereotype of the Chinese as colonizers' "agents" among Malay-speaking audiences.

Chinese-language advertisements, on the contrary, invoked Shanghai as a symbol of imagined Chinese modernity. An advertisement for the *Shanghaische Wasschery*, a Dutch-named chemical laundry company invoking Shanghai, featured illustrations of a modern young woman. For transregional Chinese merchants in the Indies, connections with metropolitan Shanghai—through commerce, culture, and social networks—were indispensable. Therefore, a company named after Shanghai could function both as a representation of urban middle-class life among the Chinese and as a symbol of Chinese people's own modernity. The advertisement here did not articulate an anti-Western modernity directly due to heavy censorship, but in a subtle and cautious way.

47 Edward W Said, *Orientalism* (Vintage Press, 1978).

48 PID monitored both left-and right-wings political activities. See Yamamoto, "Censorship in Colonial Indonesia," 259.

49 Ibid. 78–91.

50 See Tieleman and Dros. "Makanan jang paling enak rasanja," *Djawa tengah*. Agusut 10, 1928.

51 See Tieleman a d Dros. "Fijne Doperwtjes," *Algemeen handelsblad voor Nederlandsch-Indië,* 4 Agusut 1928; Tieleman and Dros. "Spersieboonen," *De Indische Courant*. 6 July, 1928.

The censorship regime in the Indies was more draconian than neighboring colonies.[52] Half of TSYP's successive editors had been deported by the Dutch colonial authorities by 1931, reflecting Dutch colonial authorities' great anxiety about TSYP's KMT affiliation.[53] The 1931 anniversary edition of TSYP experienced strong self-censorship. TSYP articles made deliberate efforts to avoid "communism" keywords, although many KMT-affiliated newspapers launched anti-communist propaganda after 1927. "Imperialism" keywords were also self-censored to avoid the risk of being considered anti-Western sentiments and as challenges to Dutch colonial rule.[54] Therefore, TSYP's narrative in 1931 fractured with the KMT party center's narrative which strongly condemned the Dutch colonial authorities' unjust treatment of Chinese.[55] In addition, the focus of the articles in the TSYP anniversary edition was to develop a pragmatic understanding of both Dutch East Indies society and China, adopting oblique and concealed discursive strategies for everyday contestation. This also reflected the commercialization of TSYP under the stringent censorship apparatus and political repression to attract more subscribers for its survival, as it faced the ongoing threat of editors being deported. Strong self-censorship was just TSYP's temporary strategy of compromise. However, during the subsequent period of the Chinese National Salvation Movement and the early Cold War, TSYP became highly incendiary, playing an important role in the mass production and dissemination of propaganda.[56]

TSYP's advertisements in this section reflected the transnational flow of knowledge and ideas and the newspaper's survival strategies in a repressive

52 Borgonjon, "Red Nanyang," 52–53, From Yamamoto, "Censorship in Colonial Indonesia."

53 Eleven of TSYP's twenty-two successive editors had been deported by the Dutch colonial authorities by 1931. See 本報歷屆編輯一覽 (A chronological list of the newspaper's editors) on page X35 and X36 of TSYP's 1931 anniversary issue.

54 A retrospective essay by a former editor of TSYP also refer to the practice of keyword-based self-censorship at the time. See Hsu Chu-ching 徐琚清, "Lü yinni qijian wangshi zayi shang 旅印尼期間 往事雜憶 (上) [Recollections and anecdotes from my time in Indonesia (Part I)]," *Yinni qiaosheng zazhi* 印尼僑聲雜誌 [The voice of overseas Chinese from Indonesia], Zhonghua Minguo Yinni Guiqiao Xiehui 中華民國印尼歸僑協會 [Indonesian overseas Chinese association], 112 (2007). https://psmtidki.ezsino.org/index.php?mod=journal&action=show&cid=8&pid=45&id=1168.

55 For example, from 1930 to 1931, KMT's *Zhongyang Qiaowu Yuekan* 中央僑務月刊 [Central overseas Chinese affairs monthly] devoted extensive coverage to strongly condemning the Dutch colonial authorities' unjust treatment of Chinese, as well as the repression of the KMT's political activities. For China's anti-Dutch boycott in 1930, see Kris Alexanderson, "Anti-Colonial Boycotts and Diasporic Activism Linking Interwar China and Colonial Indonesia: The Xiao Case," in *Colonialism, China and the Chinese*. (Routledge, 2019), 85–98.

56 See Xie, "Ambivalent Fatherland," 677–700; Zhou Taomo, *Migration in the Time of Revolution: China, Indonesia, and the Cold War* (Cornell University Press, 2019).

Dutch colony. The Chinese epistemology of the imagined Nanyang took an important part in constructing the imagined Chinese community.[57] Chinese advertisers urged their audiences to pay attention to developments in Nanyang and to embrace their own modernity. In addition, TSYP's Nanyang epistemology showed localization due to the commercialization and local readership of the newspaper. This caused TSYP's Nanyang epistemology to be situated as a third path, between the China-centric worldview and the Dutch colonial hegemonic epistemology. Thus TSYP's Nanyang epistemology provincialized both Europe and China.[58] Given the limited corpus of available TSYP issues, this section cannot analyze how TSYP's advertisements depicted their Chinese modernity in various ways, as has Hoogervorst's analysis of Sino-Malay newspapers.[59] Thus this section also has a focus on TSYP's competing modernity that was temporarily less antagonistic under the stringent press censorship and political repression in the Dutch East Indies, which reflected a cautious form of self-censorship for survival.

7 Strategic Chinese Nationalism

TSYP was a patriotic Chinese newspaper and the mouthpiece of the party-state in the KMT's official narrative, and many of TSYP's editors were also patriotic *Huaqiao* in China's narrative. Despite this, the economic interests of the advertisements in the newspaper did not comply with that of the KMT and the ROC completely. Thus the Chinese nationalism depicted in TSYP's advertisements cannot be simply interpreted as Chinese patriotism. As the minority in a Dutch colony, Chinese in late colonial Indonesia had to adopt wise strategies for survival. Indies Chinese faced unequal treatment in the racially stratified Dutch colony. Indies Chinese merchants also faced severe competition from their counterparts, including the dominating Dutch, rapidly expanding Japanese, and other European countries, in the years surrounding the Great Depression.[60] In addition, local Indonesian Muslim companies

57 Ng Kok-Hwa 黃國華, "Nanyang fengqi: Nanyang yanjiu yu Nanyang qingbao de dizhi shuxie (1928–1944) 南洋風起:《南洋研究》與《南洋情報》的地誌書寫 (1928–1944) [The rise of Nanyang studies: Topography writings in Nanyang Yanjiu and Nanyang Qingbao (1928–1944)]," *Journal of the History of Ideas in East Asia* 東亞觀念史集刊 (2022): 379–421.

58 Dipesh Chakrabarty, *Provincializing Europe: Postcolonial Thought and Historical Difference* (Princeton University Press: 2000).

59 Hoogervorst, "Language Ungoverned," 101–124.

60 From 1926 to 1931, the share of imports from Japan into the Dutch East Indies rose sharply from 9.6 percent to 16.98 percent, surpassing that of the Netherlands. And exports to the Dutch East Indies accounted for nearly 63 percent of Japan's total exports to the *Nanyo* (南洋)

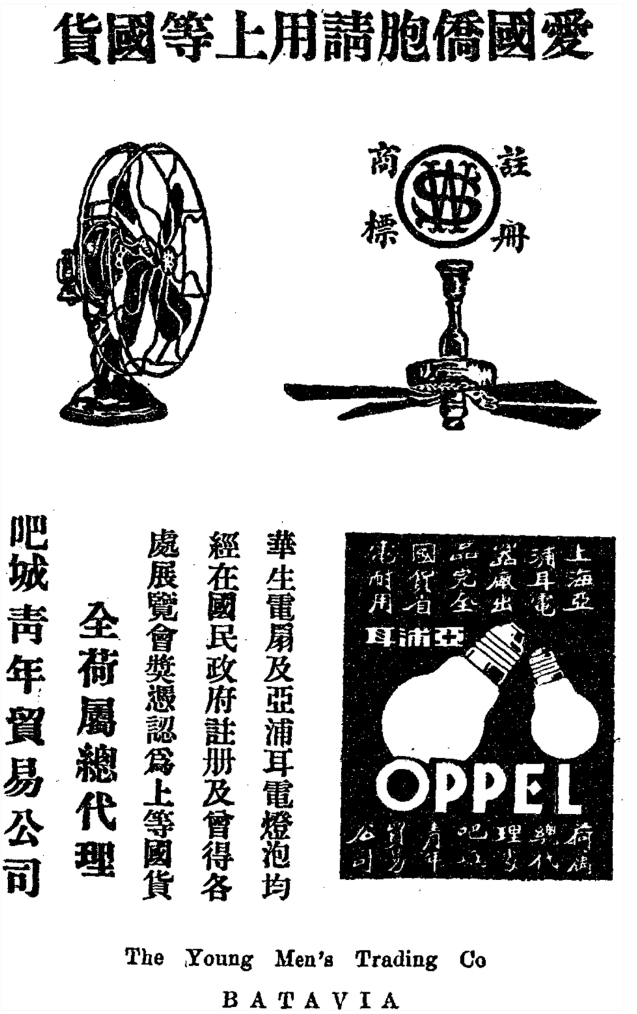


FIGURE 4 Advertisement to promote *guohuo*.
SOURCE: TENTH ANNIVERSARY EDITION OF *THIEN SUNG YIT PO,* 1931.

region. For different competitors, See Dick, Houben, Lindblad, and Thee, "Emergence of a National Economy," 111–152; For Japanese expansion, see Liu, Shu, "Zhonghua minzu tuozhi Nanyang shi," 225–232.

competed with Chinese traders and inter-ethnic tensions caused several anti-Chinese riots.[61] Given the adverse political and economic environment in the colony, TSYP's advertisers adopted Chinese nationalism as a tool to promote their products strategically in the competitive Dutch East Indies market. This section will analyze how Chinese nationalism was utilized in TSYP's advertisements for economic interests.

Advertisements of Western-introduced products often appealed to Chinese nationalist sentiment to seize market share. Figure 4 displays advertisements to promote various *guohuo* (國貨, Chinese national products) imported from China into the Dutch East Indies. The advertisements claimed that the products had received ROC government certification and recognition of *guohuo* status at Chinese exhibitions to show the high quality and authentic Chineseness of the products. One of the brands in Figure 4, the lightbulb company Oppel, which used a German-sounding brand name, exploited the intellectual property loopholes to transfer Western technology at low cost and rapidly and to secure market share through ROC government procurement contracts.[62] The slogan also aroused Chinese nationalist sentiment to advocate "patriotic overseas Chinese compatriots" (*aiguo qiaobao*, 愛國僑胞) to support *guohuo* from China. The audience of the advertisements was imagined to be patriotic Chinese concerned with the politics of China and overseas Chinese affairs. However some products that embodied much more traditional Chinese characteristics, such as references to TCM, rarely adopted such a *guohuo* strategy in marketing, because Chinese-owned TCM companies seldom faced competition from non-Chinese firms which produced TCM products. Thus the *guohuo* marketing strategy and the patriotic *Huaqiao* narrative were leveraged to displace rival products in a highly competitive market.

Some advertisements opted to highlight the disadvantageous position versus Western products to elicit readers' empathy. Chinese perfume companies *Kheun That* (群達) and *Kheun Hwat* (群發) sold luxury products, such as perfumes and leather goods.[63] But their products were less effective at evoking support for Chinese national industries than everyday products that

61 For example, the anti-Chinese Kudus riot in 1918. See Daniel Carkner, *Racial and Economic Influences in the Malay-Language Press Coverage of the Anti-Chinese Riot in 1918 Kudus, Java* (The University of British Columbia, 2019).

62 Ghassan Moazzin, "Electric Pioneers: Nationalist Lobbying, Technology Transfer, and the Origins of the Chinese Electric Lamp Industry, 1921–1937," *Enterprise & Society* 25, no. 1 (2024): 213–247.

63 See 1928 anniversary issue of TSYP.

showcased modern technology. As a result, their advertising strategies shifted towards emphasising competition with Western companies rather than labelling their products as *guohuo*. The two companies urged Chinese customers to support their business to prevent the economic interests of the Chinese from being appropriated by Westerners. This strategy also appealed to Chinese nationalist sentiment to gain greater market share.

Chinese elements could be concealed in non-Chinese advertisements to compromise with Western modernity hegemony for pragmatic economic calculation. Although the local Chinese company Lourdes displayed hybrid Chineseness in its Chinese-language advertisements to attract Chinese customers, one of its Dutch-language advertisements strategically concealed Chinese elements and emphasized the product's hygienic and nutritional value in Western terminology.[64] The readers of Dutch newspapers were primarily the Dutch and Dutch-educated elites. Constructing the product as authentically Western through advertising could attract consumers who embraced Western modernity. This strategy was not unusual; many Chinese merchants of both Peranakan and Totok affiliation also obtained multiple citizenships for more economic benefits strategically.[65] Many advertisements in TSYP also emphasized certification by the Dutch colonial government in order to deter counterfeit products and protect the companies' commercial interests. In addition, the "China-oriented" Sino-Malay newspaper *Sin Po* even carried many advertisements for Western companies in its 1930 anniversary special issue.[66] This had the benefit of bringing about a broader interracial readership for *Sin Po* and more economic profits for advertisers.

Huaqiao is are often marginalized in the Chinese nation-state's discourse.[67] The nationalist government of the ROC strictly defined *guohuo* as products "made within the territory of China" and imposed high tariffs on imports produced by overseas Chinese, despite overseas Chinese merchants' claims to Chinese identity and contributions to China.[68] Despite this, Chinese

64 For the Chinese advertisement, see figure 1 and analysis in section 5, "Bounded Hybrid Chineseness," in this article. For the Dutch advertisement, see Sinalco. "Mineraalwater Fabriek Lourdes," *Bataviaasch nieuwsblad,* 21 November 1931.

65 Xie. "Ambivalent Fatherland," 677–700; Philip A Kuhn, *Chinese among Others: Emigration in Modern Times* (Bloomsbury Publishing PLC, 2008), 277.

66 For example, the KNILM (Royal Dutch Indies Airways) advertisement and advertisement for the Dutch cigarette De Drie Musketiers distributed by Chinese company Lauw Tjin in *Sin Po* Speciaal-Nummer No.356, January 25, 1930.

67 Ong, "Chinese, But Not Quite," 1–32.

68 Kuo Huei-Ying, *Networks beyond Empires: Chinese Business and Nationalism in the Hong Kong-Singapore Corridor*, 1914–1941 (Brill, 2015).

merchants outside China continued to assert their own version of the *guohuo* definition. Famous patriotic overseas Chinese merchant Tan Kah Kee (陳嘉庚)'s rubber and shoe factories in British Malaya suffered during the Great Depression and from the ROC's strict definition of *guohuo*. Tan claimed that products made by ethnic Chinese—whether produced within or beyond China—were all Chinese products. An advertisement promoted imported rubber sports shoes produced by Tan Kah Kee's companies, claiming them as high-quality *guohuo* to attract Chinese consumers' support.[69] Although Tan's imported products from British Malaya were technically "foreign" to Indies Chinese, Tan's Indies agent leveraged pan-Chinese nationalism to persuade "Chinese compatriots" in the Indies to back Tan's business. The marketing strategy reveals how Chinese merchants in the Indies challenged the hegemonic territorial definition of *guohuo* imposed by the ROC and constructed their nonterritorial Chineseness both culturally and economically.

Some TSYP editors, who were Totoks with Meixian Hakka origin, owned local businesses and many of the advertisers in TSYP were owned by Meixian Hakka Totoks.[70] This indicates that regional and dialect-based networks continued to shape alignments within pro-China groups, even under the banner of a unified Chinese nationalism. In early twentieth-century Singapore, the Chinese patriotic newspapers *Nanyang Siang Pau* and *Sin Chew Jit Poh* also functioned as vehicles for the commercial interests of Tan Kah Kee and Tan's long-standing rival, Aw Boon Haw (胡文虎). Their intra-commercial factional rivalries also challenged the narrative of the unified Chinese patriotism.[71] These socially and economically contingent affiliations and factions challenged the monolithic discourse of Chinese nationalism, indicating the economic calculation of their strategic Chinese nationalism. In addition, TSYP's 1931 anniversary issue featured extensive coverage of Indies political, economic, and social circumstances to expand commercial networks and to promote sociopolitical rights, whereas China news did not receive comparable prominence. This indicates their pragmatism and economic calculation in the context of Dutch colonial repression.

69 Anniversary edition of TSYP, 1931.

70 For example, the former editor Wu Shenji 吳慎機's family owned the Njan Hap Kongsie (元合公司) which placed advertisements in the 1928 anniversary issue of TSYP. The owner of the company advertised in figure 1, Chen Longji (陳隆吉), was Hakka from Meixian. See "Wu Shenji 吳慎機" and "Chen Longji 陳隆吉" in Guangdong Sheng Difang Shizhi Bianzuan Weiyuanhui, "Guangdong Shengzhi."

71 Xie, "Ambivalent Fatherland," 677–700.

This section examines the flexible adoption of nationalism in TSYP's advertisements to secure their commercial interests in the unstable Dutch colony in the years surrounding the 1930s economic crisis. The fractures in the definitions of *guohuo* by the ROC government and overseas Chinese merchants indicate their conflicts of economic interests. Yao's broader argument is that Chinese nationalism is not a fixed category, but is composed of historically contingent constructions depending on the interests at stake.[72] Xie also points out that conflicting economic interests and dialect groups can influence overseas Chinese's reactions to China's political mobilization.[73] The overseas Chinese merchants' self-definition of *guohuo* not only reflects the marginalized position of *Huaqiao* within China's discourse of national economy and identity, but also reveals their autonomic agency in both economic practice and identity formation.[74] In addition, the Meixian Hakka background of TSYP's editors and advertisers also constructed a relatively exclusive Hakka commercial community, rather than a united Chinese commercial community as the KMT-affiliated newspaper propagated.

8 Conclusion

This study examines how audiences were imagined and how Chineseness was constructed in advertisements in *Thien Sung Yit Po* (TSYP) anniversary publications in late colonial Indonesia, especially in the years surrounding the Great Depression. Even though TSYP was a KMT-affiliated Chinese-language newspaper, the audience it imagined and the Chineseness it constructed were different from the essentialized China-centric versions. The audiences TSYP imagined were Chinese elites and merchants with hybridity, Chinese modernity, and Chinese literacy who resided or sojourned in an unstable late Dutch colony. TSYP served as an intermediary between Totoks and China-oriented Peranakans in a multiracial colony, exhibiting bounded hybrid Chineseness in Peranakan-dominated Chinese communities. Its localized Nanyang epistemology differed from a China-centric worldview and a hegemonic Dutch colonial epistemology, showing its own agency based on local experience, local readership, and transnational commercial network.

72 Yao Liang. "Nationalism on Their Own Terms: The National Products Movement and the Coca-Cola Protest in Shanghai, 1945–1949," *Modern Asian Studies* 51, no. 5 (2017): 1439–1468. https://doi.org/10.1017/S0026749X16000433.

73 Xie, "Ambivalent Fatherland," 677–700.

74 Ong, "Chinese, But Not Quite," 1–32.

However, under the Dutch colonial authorities' stringent newspaper censorship and political repression, TSYP's competing modernity was articulated in a subtle way. TSYP's advertisers utilized Chinese nationalism flexibly to maximize their economic interests in the difficult years surrounding the Great Depression, challenging the hegemonic narrative of the patriotic *Huaqiao*.

TSYP's advertisements were situated in the changing sociopolitical and economic circumstances in the multiracial late colony and related societies, instead of in the essentialized imagination of *Huaqiao*. Under the unequal colonial system, Indies Chinese advocated for more favorable treatment and different modernity for themselves regardless of their political stances and ties with China.[75] Indies Chinese transregional networks also enabled them to reconstruct their Chineseness based on political movements worldwide and on fierce economic competition in the late colonial society. Although the Chinese nation-state leveraged the narrative of the patriotic and essentialized *Huaqiao* to mobilize overseas Chinese for China's economic and political interests, the *Huaqiao* identity nevertheless demonstrated contingency, local characteristics, and local agency in Chinese-language advertisements in TSYP.[76]

Regardless of which version of Chineseness articulated by Chinese Indonesians, the *Orde Baru* (New Order, 1966–1998) authorities regarded Chineseness as a foreign element that had to be assimilated into the Indonesian national identity. Under Cold War–era nation-state regulation of cultural and political identities of minorities, all Chinese-language newspapers were later banned during the *Orde Baru* era.[77] While pro-ROC conservative Chinese-language newspapers, including TSYP at the time, were ceased earlier amid the turbulence of 1958. Peranakan-owned Sino-Malay newspapers which used the unofficial local language were replaced by newspapers in the national language, Standard Indonesian. Decades of a ban on Chinese-medium education also resulted in an extremely narrow readership for post-1998 Chinese-language newspapers in Indonesia. The question of "who am I" still

75 Xie, "Harnessing Nationalism," 109–131; Tom Hoogervorst, and Tarisa Melita, "'The Screaming Injustice of Colonial Relationships': Tracing Chinese Anti-Racist Activism in the Netherlands," *Bijdragen tot de taal-, land-en volkenkunde/Journal of the Humanities and Social Sciences of Southeast Asia* 177, no. 1 (2021): 27–61. https://doi.org/10.1163/22134379-bja10020.

76 Inspired by Ong, "Chinese, But Not Quite," 1–32; Kuik, "Un/Becoming Chinese,"165–168; Xie, "Ambivalent Fatherland," 677–700.

77 Except for the military-backed *Harian Indonesia*. See Leo Suryadinata, "Chinese-Language Newspapers in Indonesia: Declining Readership, Advertisement Revenue and Dearth of Journalists/Writers," In *Perspective*. ISEAS-Yusof Ishak Institute. 2020.

persistently preoccupies heterogeneous Chinese Indonesian communities against a backdrop of recurring political and economic upheavals in the country.

The term *Huaqiao* is considered controversial and outdated by many in the contemporary context, yet it remains valuable for examining Chineseness in the early twentieth century and even now. Even though Chinese communities in Singapore and Malaysia have successfully localized their identity-related terms in Mandarin, it has not occurred to the same extent elsewhere, including in Indonesia. In response to the changing geopolitical circumstances, the People's Republic of China (PRC) has officially excluded foreign citizens of Chinese descent from its *Huaqiao* category.[78] However, many Mandarin-speaking Indonesian citizens of Chinese descent continue to regard themselves as *Zhongguoren* (中國人) or *Huaqiao* partly due to past experiences of anti-Chinese discrimination and unfair treatment. Their understandings of *Huaqiao* and *Zhongguoren* challenge the PRC's nationality-based definitions and can be contingent on sociopolitical environments and economic interests. As new waves of Chinese migrants have become more visible worldwide in recent decades, this research can also offer insights into contemporary migration studies. Future research could draw on more cases of contingent identity of Chinese Indonesians, especially those in peripheral Indonesia, and situate them in the changing local and transnational sociopolitical and economic contexts, moving beyond outdated China-centric perspectives.

78 Guowuyuan Qiaowu Bangongshi 國務院僑務辦公室 [Overseas Chinese affairs office of the state council], *Guowuyuan Qiaowu Bangongshi Guanyu Yinfa "Guanyu Jieding Huaqiao Waiji Huaren Guiqiao Qiaojuan Shenfen De Guiding De Tongzhi"* 國務院僑務辦公室關於印發《關於界定華僑外籍華人 歸僑僑眷身份的規定》的通知 [Notice from the overseas Chinese affairs office of the state council on the issuance of the "Regulations on defining the status of overseas Chinese, foreign nationals of Chinese descent, returned overseas Chinese, and their family members"] (Beijing: 2009).